

Data Classification and Handling Policy

Classification, storage, transmission, and sharing requirements for organizational information.

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Key Rule

Confidential and Restricted information must remain within organization-approved systems unless an authorized exception or approved external-sharing process applies.

1. Purpose

- Define a consistent classification system for organizational information.
- Specify appropriate storage, access, transmission, and sharing requirements.
- Reduce the risk of unauthorized disclosure, loss, or misuse of organizational data.

2. Data Classification Levels

- Public — Information approved for unrestricted public distribution, such as published company announcements and approved marketing material.
- Internal — Routine business information intended for employees and authorized contractors. It must not be distributed publicly without approval.
- Confidential — Sensitive business, employee, customer, financial, technical, or operational information requiring controlled access.
- Restricted — Highly sensitive information requiring the strongest access controls. Access is limited to specifically authorized personnel on a need-to-know basis.

3. Handling Requirements

- Employees must store Confidential and Restricted information only in organization-approved systems.
- Confidential and Restricted information must not be stored on personal computers, personal phones, or personal cloud-storage accounts.
- Employees must verify recipients before sending Confidential or Restricted information.
- External sharing of Confidential information requires authorization from the responsible department head or designated data owner.
- Restricted information must not be externally shared unless explicitly authorized by the designated data owner and required controls are in place.
- Printed Confidential or Restricted material must be protected from unauthorized viewing and securely disposed of when no longer required.

4. Transmission and Sharing

- Use organization-approved secure channels when transmitting Confidential or Restricted information.
- Do not upload organizational Confidential or Restricted information to unapproved online services.
- Do not forward sensitive organizational information to personal email accounts.
- When external sharing is approved, share only the minimum information required for the business purpose.

5. Employee Responsibilities

- Classify information before storing or sharing it.
- Follow access restrictions associated with the classification level.
- Report suspected loss, accidental disclosure, or unauthorized access to the IT security team as soon as possible.
- When uncertain about classification or handling, consult the Information Security Office or data owner.

6. Policy Exceptions

- Exceptions require documented approval from the appropriate data owner and Information Security Office.
- Approved exceptions must define the scope, duration, business justification, and required safeguards.